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RESEARCH FIELD BOOK

A Comprehensive Atlas of Uttarakhand's History, Heritage, and Sacred Geography

Research on Sacred Mountains, Living Traditions: An Ethno-Historical Atlas of Uttarakhand

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Comprehensive Cultural Atlas, History, and Heritage of Uttarakhand

An Exhaustive Monograph on the Ethno-Geography, Social Fabrics, Sacred Topography, Expressive Arts, and Historical Evolution of the Central Himalayas

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Executive Introduction & Ethno-Geographic Overview

Nestled within the towering cradle of the Central Himalayas lies Uttarakhand, a region known in ancient scriptures as *Kedarakhand* and *Manaskhand*. Bordered by the high Tibetan Plateau (Xizang) to the north, the swift Mahakali River marking the border with Nepal to the east, the lush Indo-Gangetic plains to the south, and the Tons-Yamuna river basin to the west, this land forms a vital geographical and human bridge between High Asia and the South Asian mainland.

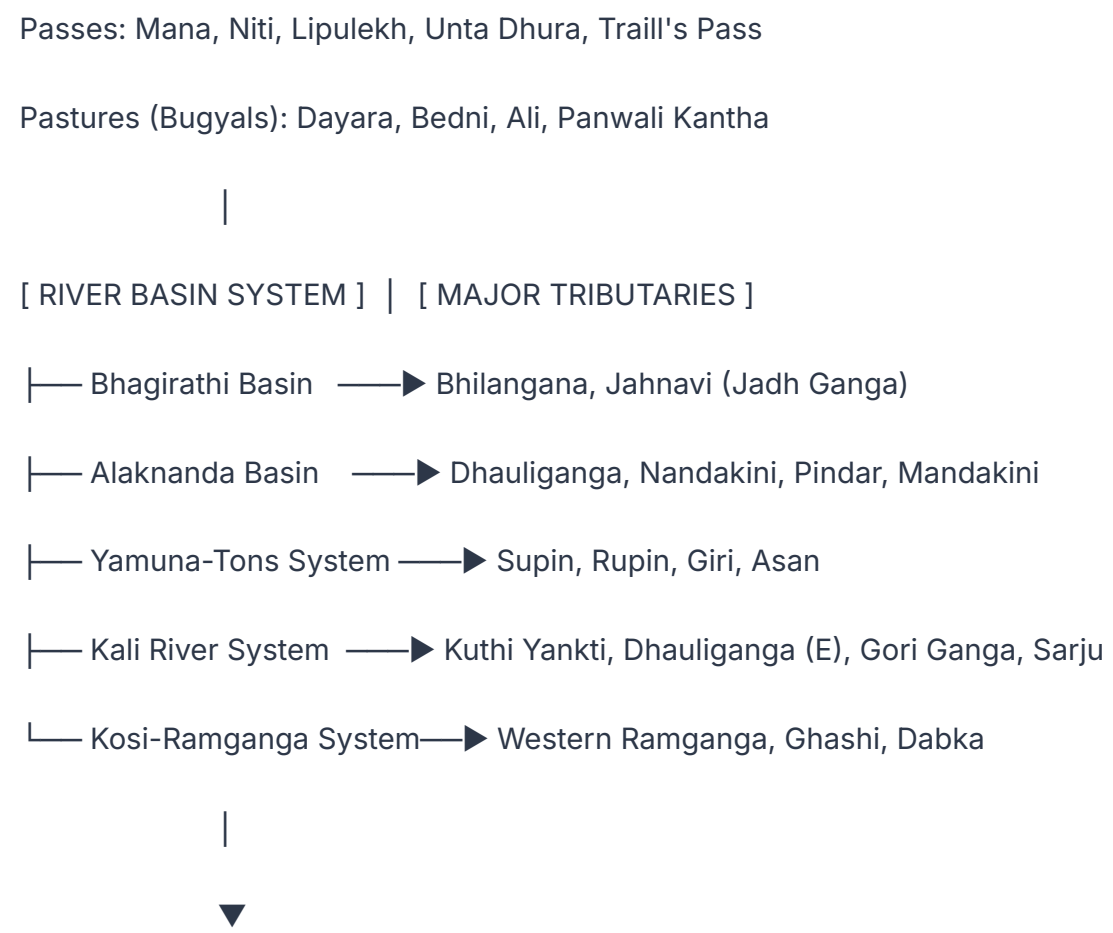
Topographical & Hydrographic Framework

The region's landscape is defined by three primary physiographic zones:

1. **The Outer Himalayas (Shivalik Hills & Tarai-Bhabar):** Characterized by porous boulders, coarse gravel belts (Bhabar), and moist alluvial marshlands (Tarai) alongside subtropical *Doon* valleys.
2. **The Lesser Himalayas (Lesser Himalayan Ranges):** Rising between 1,500 and 3,000 meters, this zone features temperate oak-rhododendron forests, terraced agrarian slopes, and deep river gorges.
3. **The Great Himalayas & Trans-Himalayan Alpine Zone:** Reaching altitudes above 3,000 meters up to 7,816 meters (Nanda Devi), this zone contains glacial basins, high-altitude pastures (*bugyals*), and dry cold-desert valleys.

[HIGH-ALTITUDE ALPINE ZONE / TRANS-HIMALAYA]

Glaciers: Gangotri, Yamunotri, Pindari, Milam, Satopanth



The hydrographic networks of Uttarakhand are dominated by two principal river systems originating from glacial snouts:

- **The Ganga River Basin System:** Formed by the confluence of the two parent streams at Devprayag—the **Bhagirathi** (originating from Gaumukh at the Gangotri Glacier) and the **Alaknanda** (originating from the Satopanth and Bhagirath Kharak glaciers). The Alaknanda acts as the master drainage channel of Garhwal, integrating five sacred confluences (*Panch Prayag*):
    - *Vishnuprayag:* Confluence with the Dhauliganga (Central).
    - *Nandaprayag:* Confluence with the Nandakini.
    - *Karnaprayag:* Confluence with the Pindar River.
    - *Rudraprayag:* Confluence with the Mandakini.
    - *Devprayag:* Confluence with the Bhagirathi, where the unified stream becomes the Ganga.

- **The Yamuna-Tons Basin System:** The Yamuna originates from the Yamunotri Glacier on the Banderpunch Massif. Its primary tributary, the **Tons (Tamasa)**, originates from the Rupin-Supin glaciers and carries a larger volume of water than the Yamuna at their junction near Kalsi.
- **The Kali (Mahakali) River System:** Forms the eastern border with Nepal, originating at Kalapani near the Lipulekh Pass. Its major Himalayan tributaries include the **Kuthi Yankti**, the **Eastern Dhauliganga**, the **Gori Ganga** (fed by the Milam Glacier), and the **Sarju** (joined by the Ramganga East).
- **The Sub-Himalayan Drainage (Kosi & Western Ramganga):** Non-glacial rivers fed by rain and springs that drain the middle ranges of Kumaon, carving out valleys around Almora, Ranikhet, and Corbett National Park before discharging into the Gangetic Plain.

These physical conditions create distinct cultural micro-climates. High mountain passes (*La* or *Dhura*)—including Mana, Niti, Unta Dhura, Darma, and Lipulekh—historically facilitated trans-Himalayan trade with Tibet, while the lower valleys fostered agrarian societies based on terrace farming and seasonal transhumance.

Ethno-Linguistic Classification

The human ecology of Uttarakhand is structured across five major ethno-cultural zones, defined by unique linguistic markers, social stratifications, and geographic boundaries.

Ethno-Cultural Zone	Primary Geographic Boundaries	Primary Languages & Dialects	Social Structure & Caste Networks	Key Geographic & Cultural Markers
Garhwal Region	Watershed of the Yamuna to the eastern boundary of the Mandakini/Pindar valleys; divided into Upper (Chamoli/Uttarkashi) and Lower (Pauri/Tehri) Garhwal.	Central Pahari: Garhwali (Dialects: Srinagarya, Badhani, Rathi, Salani, Tehri, Marchi/Jadh).	*Brahmin* (Gairola, Uniyal, Joshi, Thapliyal), *Rajput* (Khas-Jimdar, Panwar, Chauhan, Bisht), *Shilpkar/Dalit* (Auji, Tamta, Das, Kol).	Panch Badri, Panch Kedar, Koti Banal timber-bonded architecture, Pandav Lila performance traditions.

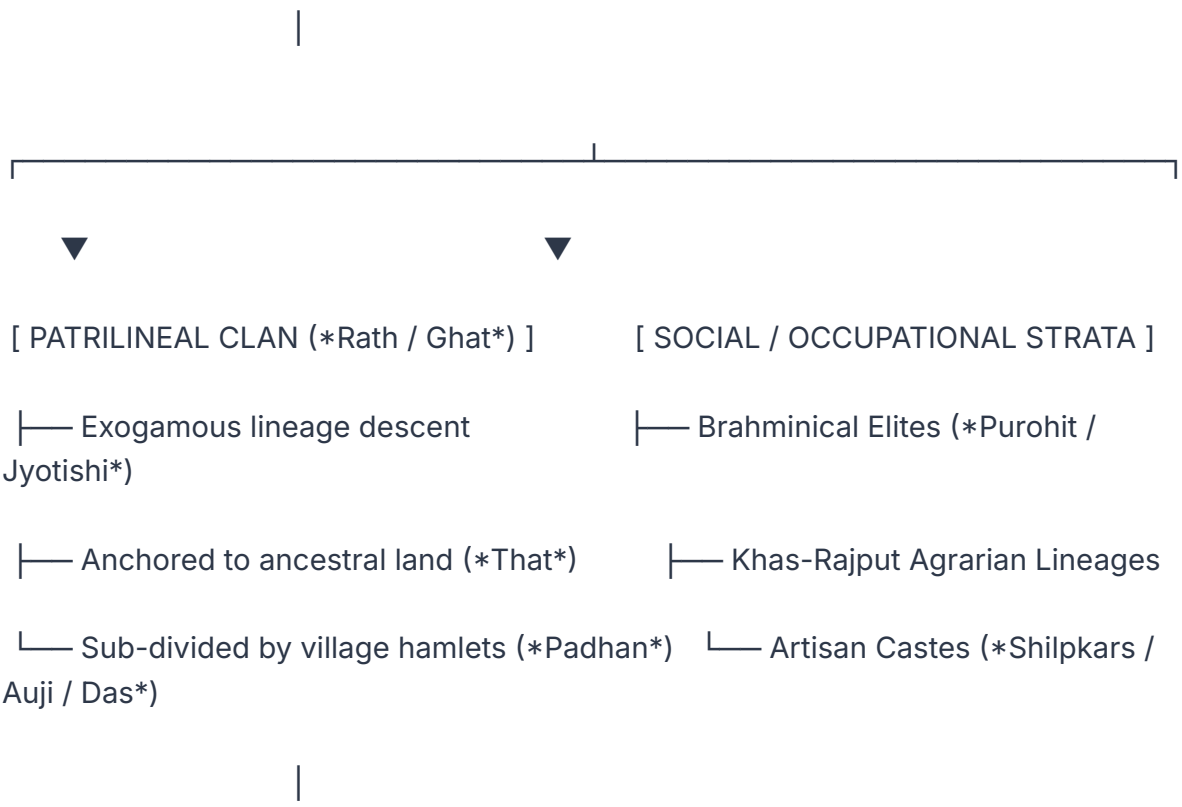
Ethno-Cultural Zone	Primary Geographic Boundaries	Primary Languages & Dialects	Social Structure & Caste Networks	Key Geographic & Cultural Markers
Kumaon Region	Catchments of the Kosi, Sarju, Gori Ganga, and Kali rivers; spanning Almora, Bageshwar, Pithoragarh, Champawat, Nainital.	Central Pahari: Kumaoni (Dialects: Khasparjiya, Kumaiya, Johari, Danpuriya, Gangoli, Soriyali, Askoti).	*Baaman* (Joshi, Pande, Pant, Upadhyaya), *Khas-Jimdar Rajput* (Rautela, Mahra, Phartyal), *Shilpkar* (Tamta, Tirwa, Lohar, Orh).	Aipan visual art, Jageshwar temple complex, Golu Devta cult of justice, Baithki & Khadi Holi rituals.
Jaunsar-Bawar	Chakrata sub-division of Dehradun district between the Yamuna and Tons rivers; trans-Giri region.	Western Pahari: Jaunsari (Dialects: Bawar, Jaunsari).	Strict hierarchical endogamy: *Khas-Rajput* and *Khas-Brahmin* (landowning aristocracy), *Kolta/Badi/Sunar* (artisan & labor groups).	Historical fraternal polyandry, *Khat-Panchayat* governance system, Mahasu Devta cult, Choli-Ghagra & Digwa attire.
Bhotia Valleys	Trans-Himalayan high alpine valleys (Johar, Darma, Chaudans, Byans, Mana, Niti, Nelang).	Sino-Tibetan / Tibeto-Burman: Rung-Lwo (Byansi, Chaudansi, Darmiya), Bhotia/Johari, Jadh.	Exogamous patrilineal clans (*Rath*); absence of traditional Hindu varna hierarchy; egalitarian merchant-pastoral structure.	Historical trans-Himalayan Indo-Tibetan trade, *Mait/Gunda* seasonal transhumance, *Rung-Kuru* youth houses, *Dhuri* rituals.
Tarai-Bhabar	Southern plains and foothills (Udham Singh Nagar, sub-plateaus of	Tharu, Buksa, Deshi/Khadi Boli, Punjabi, Bengali, Hindi.	Native tribal communities (*Tharu* matrilineal clans, *Buksa*),	Matriarchal social traits among Tharu, sacred shrine networks along

Ethno-Cultural Zone	Primary Geographic Boundaries	Primary Languages & Dialects	Social Structure & Caste Networks	Key Geographic & Cultural Markers
	Nainital and Haridwar).		alongside post-1947 refugee settlers and agrarian migrants.	water tables, dynamic agrarian plains economy.

Section 1: Regional Traditions, Customs & Social Structures

Garhwali Traditions & Customary Practices

Garhwali social structure is historically built on an interplay between early *Khas* settlers and later Indo-Aryan migrant groups from the Indian plains. [GARHWALI CLAN & KINSHIP STRUCTURE]



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[DOMESTIC & COMMUNITY RITUALS]

├── Panch-Devtas: Devi, Vishnu, Shiva, Ganesh, Surya

├── Gram Devtas: Goril, Hit, Kshetrapal, Nagaraja

└── Life-Cycle Rites: Namkaran ──▶ Janoo ──▶ Vivah ──▶ Ghat-Pujan / Pinda Daan

Clan Networks (*Rath/Ghat*)

The foundational unit of Garhwali kinship is the *Rath* or *Ghat*—an exogamous patrilineal clan tracing descent from a common ancestor. Ancestral land rights were historically held through the *That* system, where clan elders (*Thatdars*) managed resource distribution.

Religious Life & Deities

Garhwali households observe the *Panch-Devta* system (Devi, Vishnu, Shiva, Ganesh, Surya) alongside ancestral village deities (*Gram-Devtas* and *Kshetrapals*) such as **Goril**, **Hit**, **Nagaraja**, and **Narasimha**. Ancestoral spirits (*Pitri*) are regularly invoked through domestic rituals to maintain familial well-being.

Life-Cycle Rituals (*Sanskars*)

- **Namkaran (Naming Ceremony):** Observed on the eleventh day (*Ekadashi*) post-birth, involving astrological calculations by the family priest (*Purohit*) and purification of the mother and infant (*Sutak-Nivarana*).
- **Janoo (Sacred Thread Initiation):** Performed for young males among upper-caste groups, marking their entry into formal education and social responsibility.
- **Vivah (Marriage Customary Rites):** Traditionally conducted via rituals like *Kanyadaan* or *Ghar-Jawai* arrangements. Weddings feature distinct folk instrumentation (*Dhol-Damau*) and ceremonial processions across terraced paths.
- **Ghat-Pujan & Pinda Daan (Mortuary Rites):** Following cremation at river bank confluences (*Ghats*), formal mourning continues for 10–13 days, concluding with the offering of rice-flour balls (*Pinda*) to secure the soul's transition (*Pitri-Lok*).

Kumaoni Traditions & Customary Practices

Kumaoni social structure historically reflects the sociopolitical framework established during the Chand Dynasty (c. 10th – 18th century CE).

Social Stratification

- **Chauthani & Bharadwaj Baamans:** High-ranking priestly families (e.g., Joshi, Pant, Pande) imported by Chand rulers to run state administration and religious institutions.
- **Khas-Jimdars:** The indigenous agricultural populace, who were later integrated into the regional Kshatriya hierarchy as landholders.
- **Shilpkars:** Traditional artisan communities—including the *Tamta* (coppersmiths), *Orh* (masons), *Lohar* (blacksmiths), and *Tirwa* (sword-smiths)—who historically maintained essential occupational roles in the agrarian economy.

Seasonal Festivals & Agriculture

- **Harela (Festival of Greenery):** Celebrated in the month of *Shravan* (July). Ten days before the festival, seeds of five to seven grains (*barley, wheat, maize, mustard, lentils*) are sown in small wooden baskets (*Dikars*) inside the house worship room (*Puja Ghar*). The green shoots (*Harela*) are cut on the festival day and placed behind the ears of family members as a blessing of prosperity and soil fertility.
- **Khatarua:** Celebrated on the first day of the Hindu month of *Kanya Sankranti* (September). Commemorating historical military victories of the Kumaon Kingdom, huge bonfires of dried grass and twigs are lit on ridge tops, while children beat the fires with wooden sticks to ward off bad luck and seasonal illnesses.
- **Olgia / Ghee Sankranti:** Celebrated on the first day of *Bhadra* (August), marking the peak of the agricultural season. Artisans, tenant farmers, and dependents traditionally present gifts (*Olga*)—such as agricultural tools, metalware, or fresh produce—to village elders, landholders, and patrons. Consuming ghee with wild taro (*Pinalu*) leaves is a central custom of the day.

[KUMAONI SEASONAL & AGRICULTURAL RITUALS]

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[HARELA] [KHATARUA] [OLGIA / GHEE SANKRANTI]

├── Month of Shravan (July) ├── Kanya Sankranti (Sept) ├── Month of Bhadra (August)

├── Sowing 7 grains in Dikars ├── Ridge-top bonfires ├── Tributes (*Olga*) to elders

└── Symbolizes soil fertility └── Wards off bad luck └── Consuming ghee with Pinalu

Jaunsar-Bawar Traditions

The Jaunsar-Bawar region, situated in the rugged terrain between the Tons and Yamuna rivers, possesses a social structure distinct from mainstream Garhwal and Kumaon.

Social Structure & Polyandry

Historically, Jaunsari society practiced fraternal polyandry (*Pandro-Pandav system*), wherein a group of brothers shared a single wife. This custom helped prevent the fragmentation of small agricultural landholdings in steep terrain and managed family population growth. Over recent decades, this system has largely given way to monogamous family structures. [JAUNSAR-BAWAR SOCIAL & GOVERNANCE STRUCTURE]

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[KHAT-PANCHAYAT SYSTEM] [CULTURAL ATTRIBUTES]

├── *Khat* (Cluster of 5–12 villages) ├── Deities: Mahasu Devta (Chalda, Botha)

├── Headed by *Sada Siyana* & *Gaon Siyana* ├── Attire: Thalka, Ghagra, Digwa (cap)

└── Customary judicial authority outside formal courts └── Adornments: Heavy silver neck-bands (*Sutwa*)

Khat-Panchayat Governance

Local governance was traditionally maintained through the customary *Khat-Panchayat*. A *Khat* comprises a cluster of 5 to 12 villages under the leadership of a Sada Siyana (chief elder) and individual village Gaon Siyanas. This council resolves civil disputes, land boundaries, and social matters through customary law rather than formal state courts.

Material Culture & Attire

- **Men:** Wear the long woollen coat (*Thalka* or *Chola*), fitted trousers, and a round woollen cap (*Digwa*).
- **Women:** Wear bright full-flared skirts (*Ghagra*), structured tops (*Kurti*), and headscarves (*Jhongra*), adorned with heavy silver ornaments such as *Sutwa* (neck-band), *Dhagula* (bangles), and *Kanthi* necklaces.
- **Religious Focus:** Centered on the worship of **Mahasu Devta** (incarnations of Shiva/Vishnu: Botha, Pabasik, Vasik, and Chalda), whose main temple seat is located at Hanol on the banks of the Tons River.

Bhotia & Transhumant Alpine Traditions

The Bhotia populations of northern Uttarakhand (comprising the Johari, Marcha, Tolcha, Darmiya, Chaudansi, and Byansi groups) historically maintained a semi-nomadic transhumant lifestyle tied to High Asian trade routes. [BHOTIA TRANSHUMANT MIGRATION PATTERN]



[SUMMER HABITATION (*Mait*)]

├── Altitude: 3,000 m – 4,200 m

├── Duration: May to October

[WINTER HABITATION (*Gunda / Munsa*)]

├── Altitude: 1,000 m – 1,800 m

├── Duration: November to April

├── Activities: High pasture grazing, agriculture processing, crafts

└── Key Valleys: Mana, Niti, Milam, Darma

├── Activities: Trade, wool

└── Key Locations: Dharchula, Didihat, Gopeshwar

Transhumance (*Mait* and *Gunda/Munsa*)

- **Mait (Summer Habitation):** Between May and October, entire communities migrate upward to high-altitude alpine valleys (3,000–4,200 m) such as Mana, Niti, Milam, and Darma. Here, they engage in high-altitude agriculture (barley, buckwheat, *phapar*) and graze flocks of sheep and yaks in upper pasture lands (*bugyals*).
- **Gunda / Munsa (Winter Habitation):** With the arrival of snow in November, communities move down to lower-elevation winter settlements (1,000–1,800 m) around Dharchula, Didihat, Gopeshwar, and Joshi Math to process wool and trade goods.

Trans-Himalayan Trade & Trade Institutions

Until the closure of the border in 1962, Bhotia traders operated as intermediaries between India and Tibet.

- **Passes Used:** Mana, Niti, Unta Dhura, Jayanti, Damjan, and Lipulekh.
- **Traded Goods:** Indian foodgrains, sugar, cloth, hardware, and spices were exchanged for Tibetan salt, borax, raw wool, gold dust, and musk.
- **Mit-Mitrai System:** Formal trade partnerships established with Tibetan counterparts (*Gamgyas*) through written ritual pacts and shared ceremonial drinks, creating familial obligations across generations.

Social Institutions & Funerary Rites

- **Rung-Kuru / Rang-Bang:** Traditional youth centers in the eastern valleys (Darma, Byans, Chaudans) where young men and women gathered in the evenings for community singing, dance, and social interaction.
- **Dhuri / Seva Mortuary Ceremonies:** Complex socio-religious rituals intended to guide the departed soul (*Gla*) through cold mountain passes to the ancestral spirit realm, often featuring the symbolic sacrifice or dedication of a ceremonial bull (*Yak/Xag*).

Section 2: Festivals, Fairs & Sacred Pilgrimages

Major Regional Festivals

Nanda Devi Raj Jat

The largest and longest pilgrimage trek in the Central Himalayas, taking place once every twelve years. It covers a 280-kilometer barefoot journey over 19 to 20 days, passing through mountain terrain from Nauti village (near Karnaprayag) to the glacial lakes of Homkund at the base of Mount Trishul (4,000–4,500 m). [NAUTI VILLAGE] ──▶ Birth of Four-Horned Ram (*Chausingha Khadu*)

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[INITIAL STAGES] ──▶ Village-to-village processions with ceremonial *Kanswa* royal palanquin

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[BEDNI BUGYAL] ──▶ Integration of pilgrims; alpine trek across vast grasslands

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[ROOPKUND] ──▶ Ascent past the skeletal lake, traversing high mountain passes

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[HOMKUND] ──▶ Final rituals at the foot of Mt. Trishul; release of the sacred ram into the wild

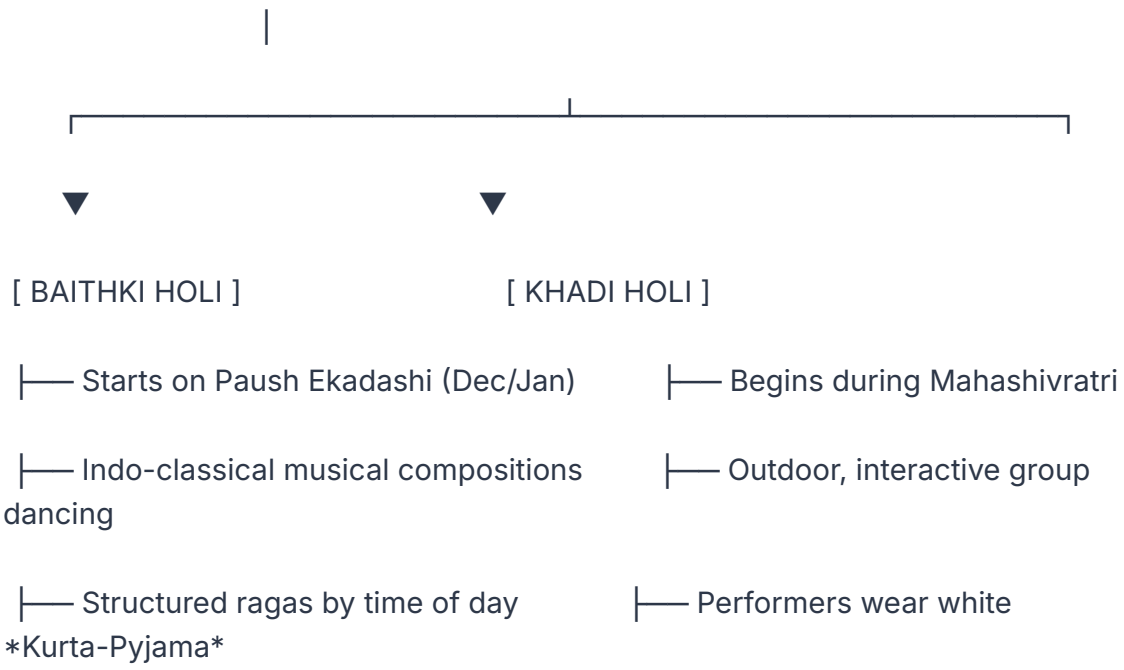
- **The Sacred Guide:** The pilgrimage is led by a four-horned ram (*Chausingha Khadu*) born in the region prior to the event. The ram self-orients toward the route and carries offerings (*Shringara*) for the goddess Nanda Devi.
- **Key Waypoints:**
    - *Nauti & Koti:* Initial rituals led by Nautiyal Brahmins and Rajputs of Chandpur Garh.
    - *Bedni Bugyal:* High alpine meadow worship and ritual dance performances.
    - *Roopkund:* Passage past the historic skeletal lake (4,800 m).
    - *Homkund:* The pilgrimage concludes at Homkund, where the *Chausingha Khadu* is released alone into the higher snows, symbolically bearing human prayers to the abode of Shiva and Parvati.

Phool Dei

A spring ritual celebrated on the first day of the Hindu month of *Chaitra* (March–April). Young children, known as *Phoolyari*, gather wild mountain flowers—such as *Buransh* (rhododendron), *Pyoli*, and *Ghendu*—and lay them on the doorsteps of houses throughout their village. In return, households give them rice, jaggery, coins, and freshly prepared sweets like *Sai*.

Baithki and Khadi Holi of Kumaon

Kumaoni Holi is distinct for its focus on classical vocal music traditions rather than water or color play alone.



└── Accompanied by Harmonium & Tabla └── Accompanied by *Hurka* & *Dhol* drums

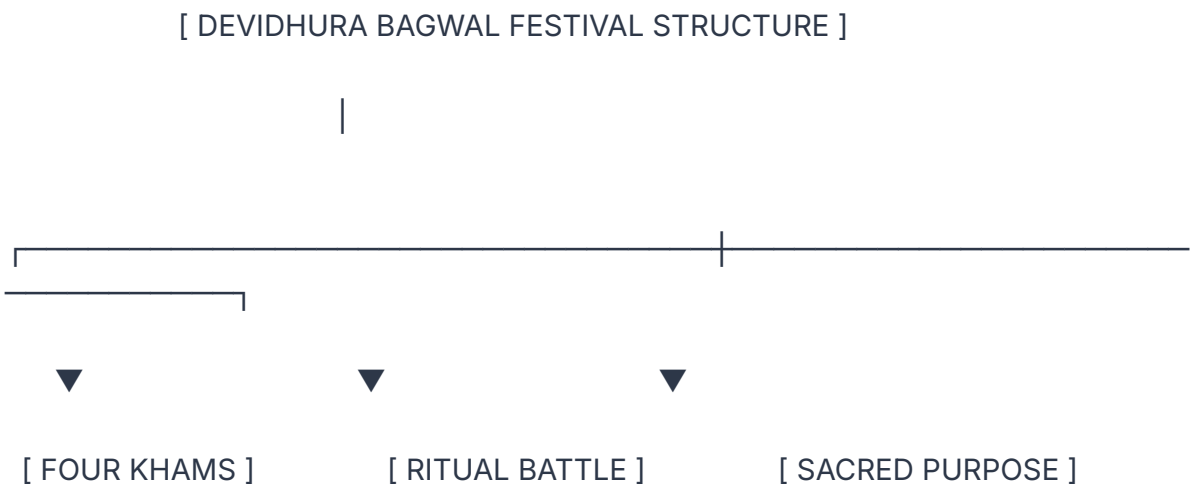
- **Baithki Holi (Seated Holi):** Begins as early as *Paush Ekadashi* (December/January). Performers gather in private courtyards and community halls to render classical compositions set to specific Hindustani *ragas* aligned with the time of day (e.g., Raga Kafi, Raga Pilu, Raga Shahana).
- **Khadi Holi (Standing Holi):** Begins around *Mahashivratri*. Performers dressed in traditional white garments (*Kurta-Pyjama* and caps) dance in circular formations across village squares, singing traditional folk verses accompanied by the *Hurka* and *Dhol*.

Major Regional Fairs (*Melas*)

Devidhura Bagwal (Champawat District)

Held annually on the full moon day of *Shravan* (Sravana Purnima) at the Varahi Devi Temple complex in Devidhura.

- **The Ritual Ritual Stone-Pelting:** Four local clans (*Khamas*—Walwal, Chamyal, Lamgaria, and Mahar) split into two opposing teams. Armed with bamboo shields (*Chhatolis*), participants hurl stones at one another in a ritual mock battle (*Bagwal*).
- **Religious Intent:** Custom holds that the fight must continue until the blood equivalent of one human sacrifice is shed on the holy ground to appease Goddess Varahi. In modern times, fruit and flowers are increasingly substituted for stones under civic regulation, though traditional stone-pelting remains central to the local lineage groups.



├── Walwal & Chamyal ├── Bamboo Shields (*Chhatolis*) ├── Blood offering equivalent

├── Lamgaria & Mahar ├── Stone / Fruit throwing ├── Dedicated to Varahi Devi

└── Clan-based lineages ├── Controlled by Priest └── Concludes on priest signal

Bageshwar Uttarayani Mela

Held at the confluence of the Sarju and Gomti rivers in Bageshwar on *Makar Sankranti* (January).

- **Historical Significance:** Beyond its religious role, the 1921 Uttarayani Mela served as the site for the non-violent abolition of the colonial *Coolie Begar* (forced uncompensated labor) system, when thousands of villagers dumped their labor registers into the Sarju waters under the leadership of Badri Datt Pande.
- **Commercial Exchange:** Serves as a trade market where trans-Himalayan crafts, alpine herbs, woolens, copper cookware, and livestock are bought and sold.

Additional Fairs

- **Joljibi Mela:** Held at the confluence of the Kali and Gori rivers on the India-Nepal border, serving as an international trading site for Bhotia weavers, Nepalese merchants, and regional farmers.
- **Gauchar Mela:** An annual industrial and cultural fair in Chamoli district established in 1943 to encourage commerce and community outreach across mountain valleys.
- **Haridwar Kumbh Mela:** A major pilgrimage held every twelve years (with an intermediate *Ardh Kumbh* every six years) where millions gather for ritual bathing in the Ganga at Har Ki Pauri.

Section 3: Performing Arts: Folk Dance & Music Ensembles

Folk Dances

Chholiya

A martial sword-dance native to Kumaon, performed during wedding processions and regional celebrations. Originating among the *Khas Kshatriyas*, dancers dress in traditional attire (white *Choga*, red turban, fitted trousers) and execute complex sword-and-shield patterns designed to ward off malevolent spirits from the bridal party. [MARIAL DANCES] [RITUAL / SACRED] [COMMUNITY / SOCIAL]



Chholiya Pawarw Pandav Lila Harul Chaufula Jhumailo

(Sword/Shield; Kumaoni) (Heroic epic reenactment) (Trance-possession; Garhwal) (Jaunsar; Thali dance) (Lyrical duet; no instruments) (Seasonal; women; melancholic themes)

Pandav Lila (Pandav Nritya)

A multi-day ritual drama native to Garhwal that reenacts chapters of the *Mahabharata*.

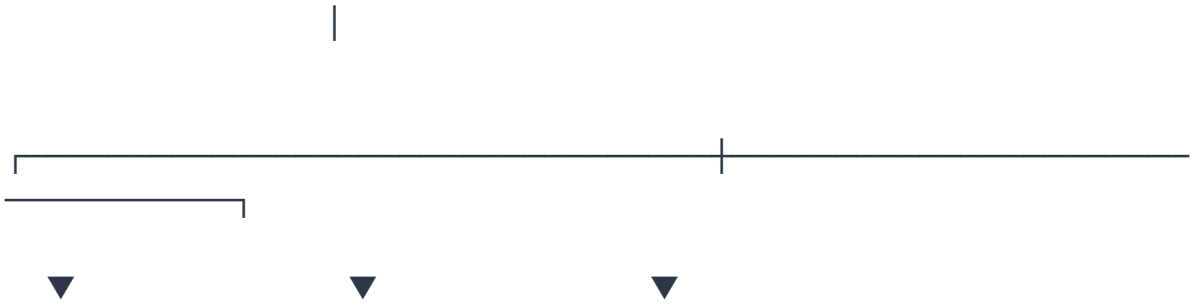
- **Trance and Spirit Possession:** Villagers assume the roles of the five Pandava brothers, Draupadi, and Krishna. Accompanied by specific rhythms played on the *Dhol-Damau*, the performers enter physical trance states (*Bhaan* or *Avatar*).
- **Baan-Pujan & Weapons:** The performance features weapons (*Baan*, spears, bows, swords) stored in the village shrine. The ritual ends with a ceremonial feast and the ritual laying-down of these arms.

Regional Social & Seasonal Dances

- **Chaufula:** A celebratory Garhwali dance performed by men and women in opposing lines or concentric circles. It relies on rhythmic hand-clapping and footwork without instrumental backing.
- **Jhumailo:** A seasonal women's dance that reflects on life's hardships, love, and separation from home, performed from *Phool Dei* through the spring season.
- **Hurkiya Baul:** A dance performed during the cultivation of paddy and maize in Kumaon. A lead singer plays the *Hurka* drum, reciting historical ballads while agrarian workers plant crops in time to the music.
- **Harul & Thali Nritya:** Traditional dances of Jaunsar-Bawar. *Thali Nritya* involves balancing brass plates on fingers or head while spinning to high-tempo drumbeats.

Musical Heritage & The Dhol-Damau System

The folk music of Uttarakhand is anchored by the **Dhol-Damau** instrument combination, operated primarily by professional musician castes (such as the *Auji*, *Das*, and *Bajgi*).



Dhol Sagar (The Scripture of the Drum)

An ancient oral tradition preserved by master drummers. The *Dhol Sagar* classifies dozens of distinct rhythmic patterns (*Taal*) and beat sequences, associating each with specific times of day, life-cycle rituals, or divine invocations.

- *Badd-Dev Taal:* Rhythms meant to invoke mountain deities.
- *Pandav Taal:* Specific rhythms mapped to individual Pandava characters during Pandav Lila performances.
- *Nauti/Yatra Taal:* Rhythms used to guide formal ritual processions across long distances.

Instrument Classification

Instrument Category	Name	Physical & Acoustic Characteristics	Cultural Context & Usage
Percussion (Membranophones)	**Dhol**	Two-headed wooden barrel drum, played with a wooden stick (*Lanti*) on the bass side and a bare hand on the treble side.	Master instrument; leads all rituals, processions, and formal gatherings.
	Damau	Small twin copper-bowl kettle drum played with two thin wooden sticks.	Provides high-pitched rhythmic counterpoints to the Dhol.
	Hurka	Hourglass-shaped drum with leather lacings; pitch is adjusted by squeezing the waist strings under the arm.	Accompanying instrument for Hurkiya Baul, Kumaoni ballads, and epic recitations.
Wind / Brass (Aerophones)	**Bhankora**	Long, straight, trumpet-like brass wind instrument with a wide bell.	Plays low sustained tones; used exclusively during religious processions and ritual practices.
	Ransingha	S-shaped or C-shaped copper	Used in battles, martial dances like

Instrument Category	Name	Physical & Acoustic Characteristics	Cultural Context & Usage
		horn assembled in two or three interlocking sections.	Chholiya, and royal processions.
	Algroza	Pair of wooden flutes played simultaneously using continuous breathing techniques.	Pastoral instrument used by shepherds across high pastures (*bugyals*).
Idiophones (Autophones)	**Thali**	Flat bronze plate struck on its rim or flat back with a thin wooden stick.	Creates crisp, high-frequency tempos for Jaunsari dances and regional folk songs.

Bards & Folk Singers

Oral traditions were historically preserved and performed by traveling bards (*Ghuriyas*, *Hurkiyas*, *Das*). These musicians passed down long narrative epics (*Jagars*, *Pawarws*) through memory alone across generations.

Section 4: Languages, Literature & Folk Texts

Central Pahari Languages

The primary local languages of Uttarakhand belong to the **Central Pahari** subgroup of Indo-Aryan languages. [CENTRAL PAHARI LANGUAGES]

▼ ▼

[GARHWALI] [KUMAONI]

├── Northern: Badhani, Marchi ├── Eastern: Soriyali, Askoti

├── Southern: Salani, Rathwa ├── Western: Khasparjiya, Danpuriya

└── Central: Srinagarya, Tehri └── Southern: Kumaiya

- **Garhwali Language Groups:**
  - *Srinagarya:* Historically used as the court language of the Panwar Kings in Srinagar (Garhwal).
  - *Salani:* Spoken in southern Pauri Garhwal; heavily influenced by plains dialects.
  - *Badhani & Marchi:* Spoken in high-altitude Chamoli; reflects interaction with trans-Himalayan Tibetan dialects.
- **Kumaoni Language Groups:**
  - *Khasparjiya:* Spoken in the central Almora district; historically considered the literary standard for Chand-era documentation.
  - *Gangoli & Soriyali:* Dialects spoken in the eastern belt around Pithoragarh and Gangolihat.
  - *Danpuriya:* Spoken in northern Bageshwar, featuring distinct vowel shifts and pronunciations.

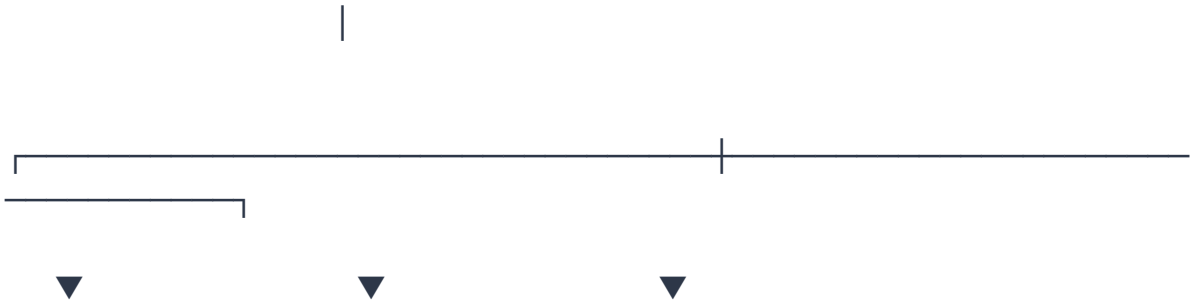
Folk Literature & Oral Epics

Malushahi & Rajula

An epic romance set between the Kumaoni hills and the Bhotia borderlands. It follows the love story between Prince Malushahi of Bairat (Chaukhutia) and Rajula, a Bhotia merchant's daughter from Johar Valley. The narrative traces their long journeys, magical transformations, and resistance to parental and political opposition, ending in their eventual union.

Jeetu Bagdwal and the Aanchharis

The ballad of **Jeetu Bagdwal**, a flute player from Bagddhar who captured the attention of the *Aanchharis* (mountain fairies/forest nymphs) with his music. The fairies whisked his spirit away to the unseen world, and today his story is invoked during *Jagar* sessions to appease mountain spirits. [MAJOR FOLK LITERATURE NARRATIVES]



Nagaraja & Bhana

A popular ballad centered on divine intervention and devotion, describing how Krishna/Nagaraja fell in love with Bhana, a woman from the hills, and overcame social barriers to protect his devotees.

Literary Figures

Mola Ram (1743–1833)

A prominent poet, painter, and scholar who served at the Panwar court in Srinagar Garhwal. He authored significant historical texts in Braj Bhasha and Garhwali prose—including the Garhrajvansh Kavya—which document contemporary court politics and royal lineages.

Abodh Bandhu Bahuguna (1927–2000)

A foundational figure in modern Garhwali literature. He systematized Garhwali grammar and published seminal creative works—including *Gaad Mynte Ki Ganga* and *Yuga Vani*—advocating for the formal recognition and preservation of Central Pahari languages.

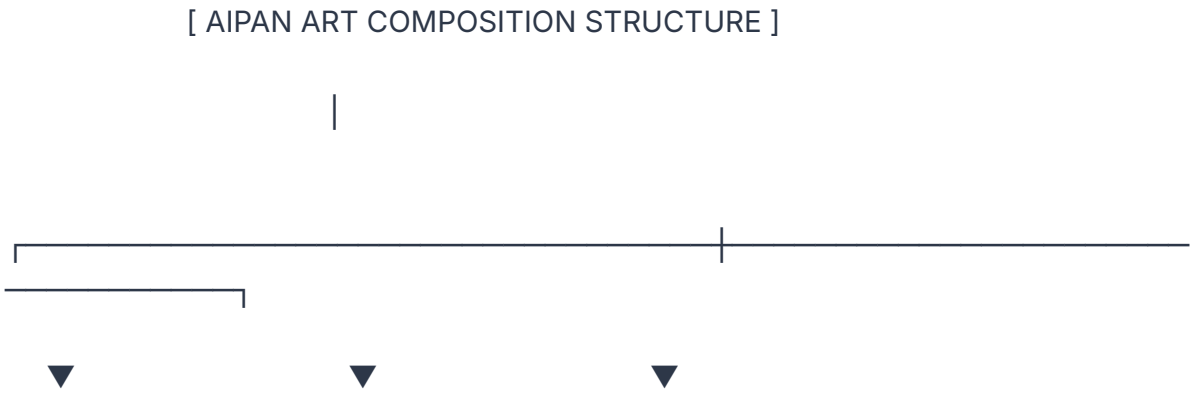
Section 5: Crafts, Visual Arts & Vernacular Architecture

Decorative & Visual Arts

Aipan (Ritual Floor Art)

A sacred folk art practiced primarily by women in Kumaon.

- **Technique:** The base surface (courtyards, wooden thresholds, altars) is painted with a rich terracotta-red clay called **Geru**. Patterns are then drawn over it using **Biswar**—a white paste made from soaked, finely ground rice flour applied with the fingertips.



- **Key Patterns & Symbols:**
  - *Chowki:* Geometric representations of deity seats (e.g., *Saraswati Chowki*, *Lakshmi Chowki*, *Chamunda Chowki*).
  - *Vasudhara:* Continuous vertical lines drawn at house entrances, created by dropping liquid *Biswar* in unbroken streams to ensure prosperity and household protection.

- *Lakshmi Pujan:* Features stylized footprints of Goddess Lakshmi pointing inward toward the inner worship room (*Puja Ghar*).

Garhwal School of Miniature Painting

A distinct branch of the Pahari miniature tradition, pioneered by the artist **Mola Ram**.

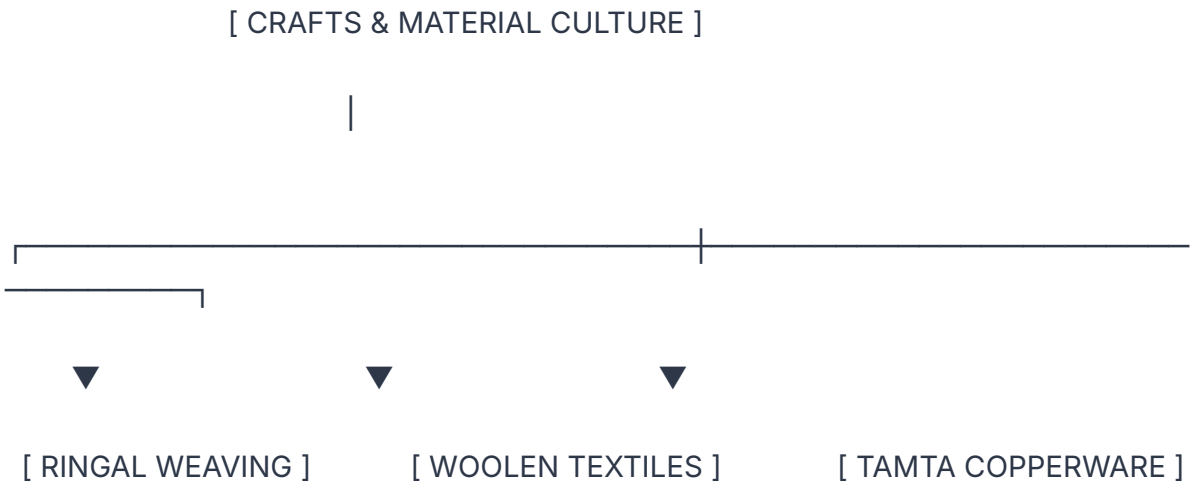
- **Stylistic Features:** Soft pastel color palettes, lyrical human figures with curved eyebrows, slender eyes, elongated necks, and detailed depictions of native mountain flora and landscapes. Common themes include scenes from the *Rasamanjari*, *Gita Govinda*, and royal court proceedings.

Traditional Handicrafts

Ringal Bamboo Weaving

A traditional craft practiced across high-altitude villages using *Ringal* (a native dwarf bamboo species: *Arundinaria falcata*).

- **Products:** Artisans craft *Kandi* (heavy-duty woven baskets for farm transport), *Doka* (harvesting baskets), *Supa* (winnowing trays), and modern mats.



Woolen Textiles

Practiced widely by Bhotia communities in northern districts.

- **Products:** Heavy hand-woven wool blankets (*Thulma*), coarse pile rugs (*Chutka*), lightweight shawls (*Pankhi*), and decorative carpets (*Tuldhan*) decorated with high-altitude floral and Asian geometric motifs.

Tamta Copperware of Almora

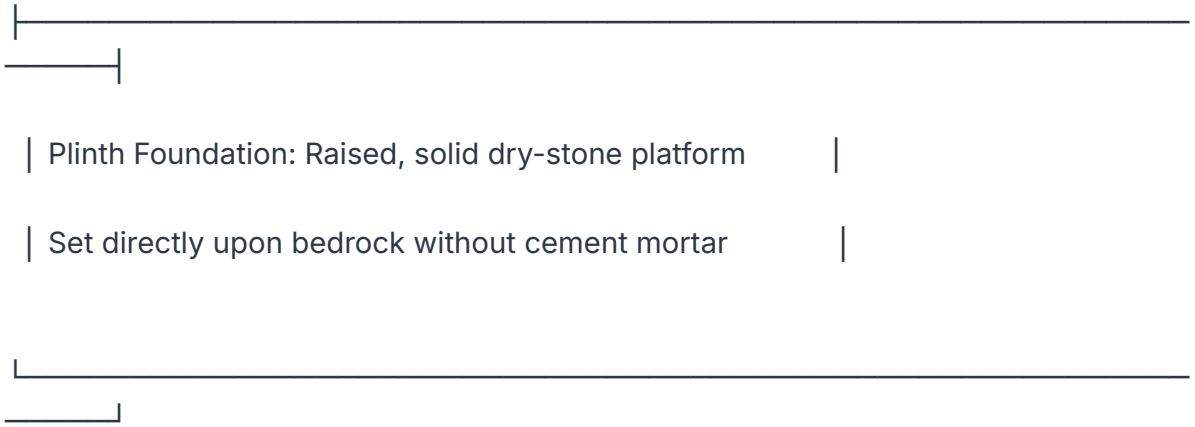
A coppersmithing tradition concentrated in Almora's *Tamta Mohalla*. Craftsmen hand-hammer thick copper sheets to produce large water vessels (*Gaggar*), cooking pots (*Taula*), and sacred ceremonial hardware.

Vernacular Architecture

Koti Banal Architecture

An ancient, earthquake-resistant timber-bonded masonry style unique to the Yamuna, Tons, and Bhagirathi valleys of Upper Garhwal, named after the village of Koti Banal where multi-story structures have stood for over 800 years. [KOTI BANAL SEISMIC-RESISTANT STRUCTURE]





- **Key Structural Specifications:**
    a. *Raised Stone Foundation:* Heavy dry-stone plinth built directly on bedrock, raising the building's center of gravity and absorbing seismic shockwaves.
    b. *Double-Timber Framing:* Paired wooden beams (*Deodar*) run horizontally along inner and outer wall faces.
    c. *Dry-Stone Infill:* Stone masonry fitted into the timber frames without mortar, allowing the structure to flex during seismic events without collapsing.
    d. *Corner Lap-Joints:* Interlocking timber corners fastened with wooden pegs (*Paas*), avoiding rigid iron joints.

Traditional Kumaoni House Layout

- **Goth (Ground Floor):** Low-ceilinged lower level used to house livestock, where animal body heat helps warm the living quarters above.
- **Pauri / Chakhata (Upper Living Floor):** Reached by exterior stone steps, housing the family rooms and kitchen (*Rasoi*).
- **Pathal Roofs:** Sloped roofs covered with thin, hand-chiseled slate tiles (*Pathal*) resting on Deodar wood rafters.
- **Kholi (Carved Wooden Doorframe):** Intricately carved main entrances featuring geometric patterns, floral motifs, and figures of Ganesh (*Ganesh-Kholi*).

Section 6: Chronological Historical Timeline

ANCIENT ERA MEDIEVAL RULE COLONIAL & RESISTANCE MODERN STATEHOOD

Lakhudiyar Rock Art ——▶ Katyuri Kingdom ——▶ Gurkha Occupation ——▶ Chipko Movement (1973)

Kuninda Kingdom ——▶ Panwars & Chands ——▶ British Rule (1815) ——▶ Statehood (2000)

Ancient Era

- **Prehistoric Period:** Rock shelters at **Lakhudiyar** (Almora), **Gorakhya Udyan** (Chamoli), and **Kimni** feature early red-ochre cave paintings depicting human figures, animals, and geometric dance patterns.
- **c. 2nd Century BCE – 3rd Century CE:** Dominance of the **Kuninda Kingdom**. Silver and copper coinage bearing the name of King **Amoghbhuti** points to organized regional trade networks along major river corridors.
- **257 BCE:** Emperor Ashoka erects a major rock edict at **Kalsi** (at the junction of the Tons and Yamuna rivers), directing citizens toward Dhamma and non-violence.
- **c. 6th – 11th Century CE:** Rise of the **Katyuri Dynasty**, operating from the Katyur Valley (Baijnath/Joshimath). The Katyuris built major stone temple complexes across northern and central districts before breaking apart into smaller principalities.
- **8th Century CE: Adi Shankaracharya** travels to Uttarakhand, establishing the **Jyotirmath (Joshi Math)** monastery, renovating the sacred shrines at Kedarnath and Badrinath, and revitalizing Sanatana Dharma across the northern Himalayas.

[MEDIEVAL DYNASTIC MAP]



[PANWAR DYNASTY (Garhwal)]

├── Founded by Kanakpal (c. 888 CE)

├── Ajaypal unifies 52 Garhs (c. 1500)

├── Fortified capital at Srinagar

└── Defended against invaders (Rani Karnavati)

[CHAND DYNASTY (Kumaon)]

├── Founded by Som Chand (c. 10th C)

├── Capital moved to Almora (1560)

├── Golden Era under Rudra & Baz Bahadur

└── Promoted art, Aipan & administrative law

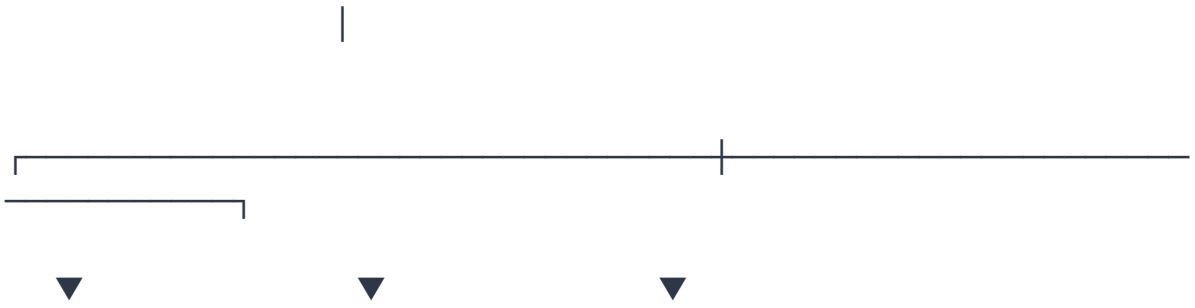
Medieval Era

- **c. 888 CE:** Prince **Kanakpal** arrives from Malwa, founding the **Panwar (Parmar) Dynasty** at Chandpur Garhi.
- **c. 10th Century CE: Som Chand** establishes the **Chand Dynasty** at Champawat in Kumaon, initiating a line that later moved its capital to Almora in 1560 under King Balo Kalyan Chand.
- **c. 1500 CE:** King **Ajaypal** of the Panwar dynasty unifies fifty-two independent mountain forts (*Garhs*), consolidating the unified kingdom of **Garhwal** with its royal capital at Srinagar.
- **1630s CE: Rani Karnavati** of Garhwal (regent for her young son Prithvipat Shah) defeats invading Mughal forces sent by Shah Jahan, earning the epithet *Nakti Rani* ("The Cut-Nose Queen") for cutting off the noses of captured enemy soldiers.
- **17th – 18th Century CE:** Kumaon experiences a high point in administration and culture under Chand rulers like Rudra Chand, Baz Bahadur Chand, and Jagat Chand.

Gurkha Occupation & Colonial Rule

- **1790 CE:** The Nepalese Gurkha army invades Kumaon, defeating the Chand forces at the Battle of Havalbagh and ending Chand rule.
- **1804 CE:** Gurkha forces invade Garhwal, defeating King Pradyuman Shah at the **Battle of Khurbura** in Dehradun. The subsequent twelve-year period of harsh Gurkha military rule is remembered locally as the **Gorkhyani**.

- **1814–1815 CE:** The Anglo-Nepalese War breaks out. British forces under David Ochterlony and Edward Gardner defeat the Gurkhas, leading to the **Treaty of Sugauli (1815)**.
- **1815–1947 CE:**
    - *British Garhwal & Kumaon:* Lower Garhwal and Kumaon are organized directly into British administrative districts under a Commissioner (including Henry Ramsay, long-serving Commissioner of Kumaon).
    - *Tehri Princely State:* The Panwar royal line is restored in the western territory, establishing the princely state of **Tehri Garhwal** under King Sudarshan Shah.
    - *Military Formations:* The British establish the **Garhwal Rifles** (1887) and the **Kumaon Regiment** (1945), drawing heavily on local mountain soldiers.



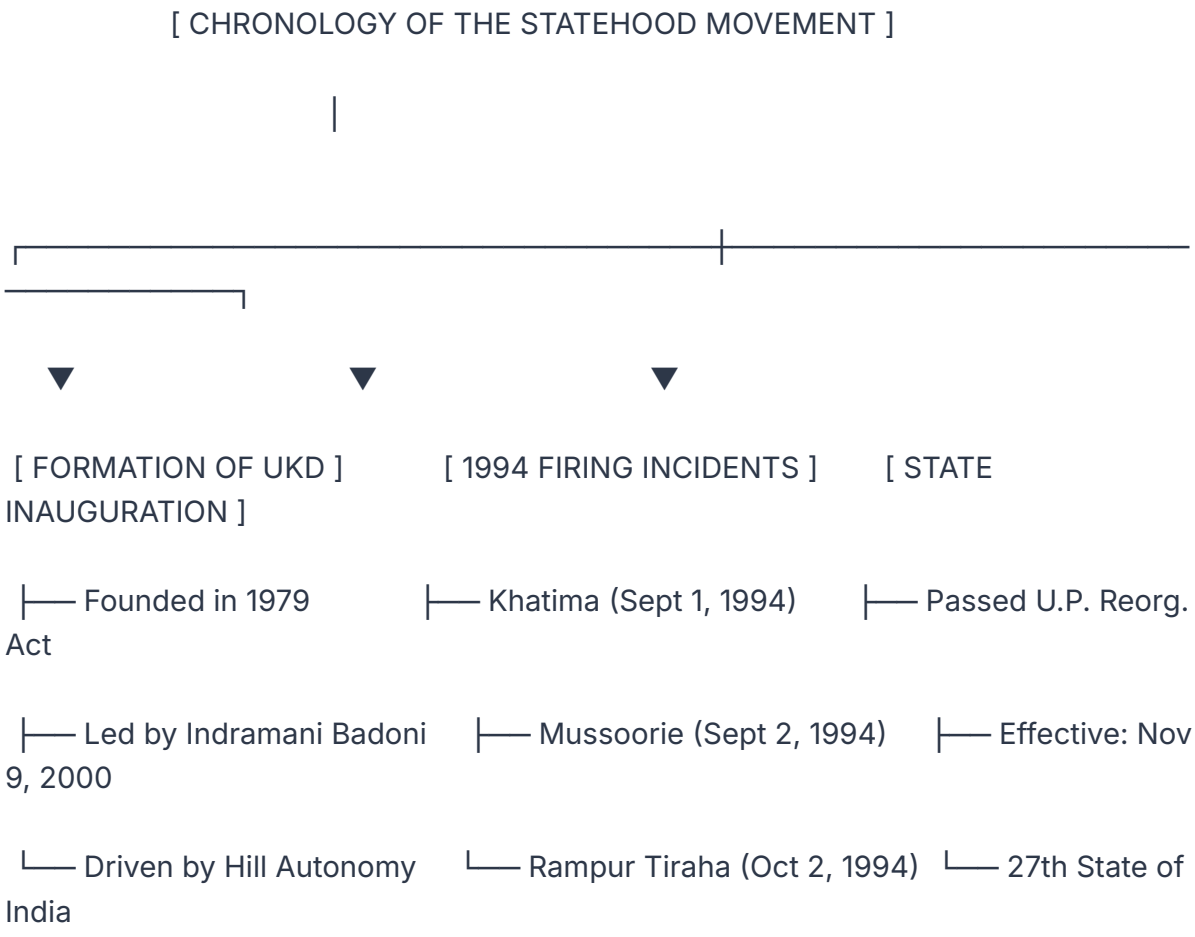
Social & Freedom Movements

- **January 1921:** The **Anti-Coolie Begar Movement** reaches its climax during the Uttarayani Mela in Bageshwar. Under Badri Datt Pande, Hargovind Pant, and Victor Mohan Joshi, thousands of villagers dump forced-labor registers into the Sarju River, ending the *Begar* system.

- **April 23, 1930:** The **Peshawar Incident**. Havildar **Veer Chandra Singh Garhwali** refuses orders from British officers to open fire on unarmed Pashtun *Khudai Khidmatgar* protesters in Peshawar, leading to his court-martial and sentence.
- **1939–1944:** Formation of the **Tehri Rajya Praja Mandal** under **Sridev Suman** to oppose autocracy in Tehri State. Sridev Suman dies in 1944 following an 84-day hunger strike in prison.

Post-Independence & The Statehood Movement

- **August 1, 1949:** Tehri Princely State formally merges into the Indian Union, becoming a district of Uttar Pradesh.
- **March 1973:** The **Chipko Movement** begins in Mandal village (Chamoli district), gaining international attention when **Gaura Devi** and local women hug trees to prevent commercial logging. Environmentalists **Sunderlal Bahuguna** and **Chandi Prasad Bhatt** help lead the campaign.



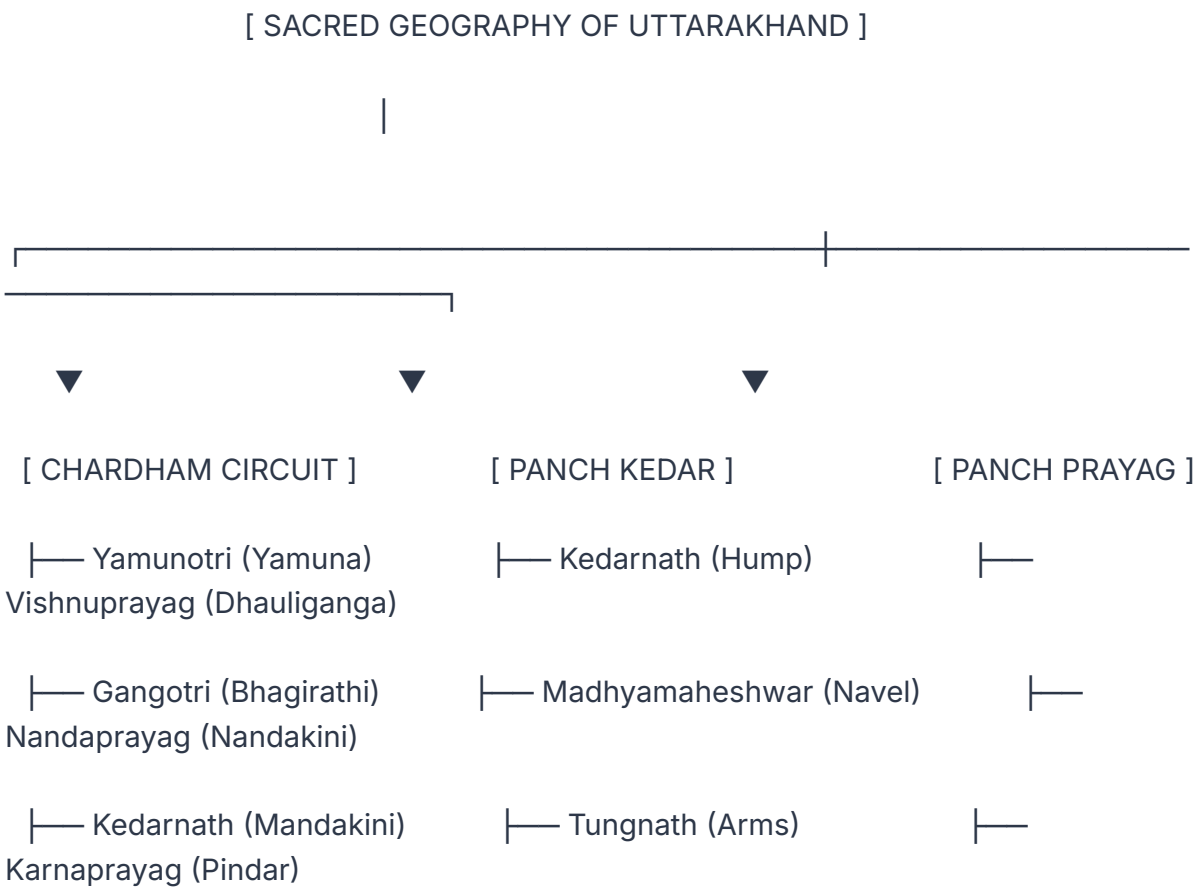
- **1979:** The **Uttarakhand Kranti Dal (UKD)** is founded under **Indramani Badoni** (often called the "Gandhi of Uttarakhand") to push for a separate hill state.
- **1990s Uprisings & Firing Incidents:** Statehood protests intensify across the region, leading to tragic confrontations:

- *Khatima Firing (Sept 1, 1994):* Police open fire on peaceful statehood demonstrators.
- *Mussoorie Firing (Sept 2, 1994):* Protesters killed during statehood rallies.
- *Rampur Tiraha Incident (Oct 2, 1994):* UP police attack statehood activists traveling to Delhi for a peaceful demonstration.

- **November 9, 2000:** The Indian Parliament passes the Uttar Pradesh Reorganisation Act, officially establishing the region as the 27th state of the Republic of India (initially named *Uttaranchal*, later renamed **Uttarakhand** in 2007).

Section 7: Heritage Sites, Sacred Geography & Architecture

Sacred Pilgrimage Circuits



└── Badrinath (Alaknanda)　　├── Rudranath (Face)　　├── Rudraprayag (Mandakini)

└── Kalpeshwar (Hair)　　└── Devprayag (Bhagirathi)

Chardham Circuit

The four foundational pilgrimage sites tucked into the high Himalayas:

- **Yamunotri:** Located at 3,293 m; dedicated to Goddess Yamuna, featuring thermal hot springs like *Surya Kund*.
- **Gangotri:** Located at 3,100 m; dedicated to Goddess Ganga, marking the spiritual site where King Bhagiratha invoked the river to Earth.
- **Kedarnath:** Located at 3,583 m along the Mandakini River; one of the twelve *Jyotirlingas* of Shiva.
- **Badrinath:** Located at 3,133 m along the Alaknanda River; dedicated to Vishnu as *Badri Narayan*.

Panch Kedar

Five mountain shrines dedicated to Shiva, where different body parts of the divine bull form are worshipped according to Mahabharata tradition:

1. **Kedarnath:** The hump of Shiva.
2. **Madhyamaheshwar:** The navel (*Nabhi*).
3. **Tungnath:** The arms (*Bahu*)—the highest Shiva temple in the world (3,680 m).
4. **Rudranath:** The face (*Mukh*).
5. **Kalpeshwar:** The hair coils (*Jata*).

Panch Prayag

The five sacred river confluences along the Alaknanda River course:

1. **Vishnuprayag:** Alaknanda + Dhauliganga.
2. **Nandaprayag:** Alaknanda + Nandakini.
3. **Karnaprayag:** Alaknanda + Pindar.
4. **Rudraprayag:** Alaknanda + Mandakini.
5. **Devprayag:** Alaknanda + Bhagirathi (forming the unified Ganga).

Panch Badri

Five shrines dedicated to Vishnu across Chamoli district: **Badrinath (Vishal Badri)**, **Yogdhyan Badri** (Pandukeshwar), **Bhavishya Badri** (Subain), Vridha Badri (Animath), and Adi Badri (a cluster of 16 ancient stone temples).

Architectural Heritage Sites



Jageshwar Dham (Almora District)

A sanctuary of over 124 stone temples dating from the 7th to 14th centuries CE, built primarily by Katyuri rulers. Architectural styles range from post-Gupta forms to refined *Nagara* tower structures. Key shrines include the *Maha Mrityunjaya Temple* and the *Jageshwar Main Temple*, set within a dense Deodar forest.

Katarmal Sun Temple

A 9th-century CE temple dedicated to the Sun God (Burhadita), situated on a high ridge near Almora. It features a central sanctuary surrounded by 45 smaller shrines, known for detailed stone masonry and carved wooden door frames (some of which are preserved in the National Museum).

Lakhamandal Temple Complex

Located along the Yamuna River in Jaunsar-Bawar. Built in the classic Nagara style, the site houses an extensive collection of ancient stone sculptures, twin carved stone guards (*Jai and Vijai*), a polished black-stone Shiva Linga, and inscriptions in the ancient Shell Script (*Sankha Lipi*).

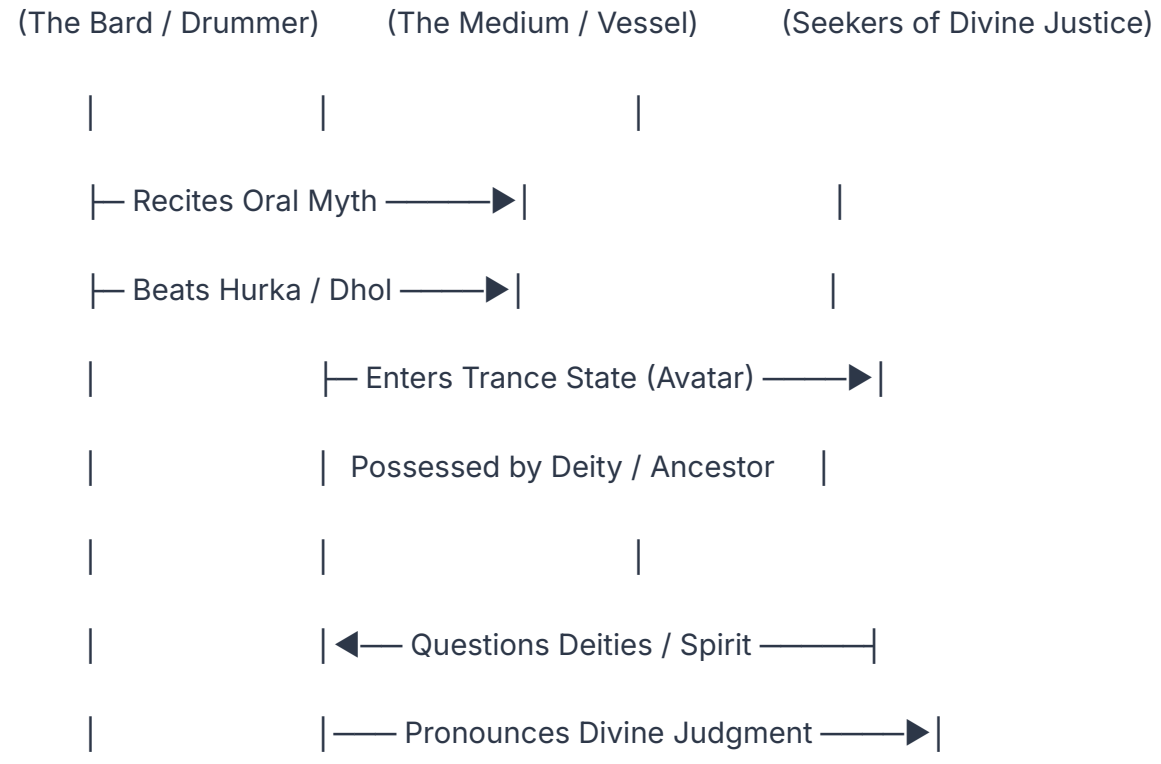
Hemkund Sahib

A major Sikh pilgrimage destination situated beside a high-altitude glacial lake at 4,160 meters, surrounded by seven snow-capped peaks. Mentioned in Guru Gobind Singh's Bachittar Natak as the site of his prior-life meditation, the complex features a distinctive star-shaped Gurdwara built to withstand winter snow loads.

Section 8: Oral Traditions, Shamanism & Traditional Knowledge

The Jagar Tradition (Shamanic Ritual Performance)

The **Jagar** is a mediumistic ritual practiced across Garhwal and Kumaon to invoke ancestors, village gods, and spirit entities (*Gram-Devtas*, *Bhoot*, *Masani*, *Narsingh*, *Golu*) to resolve local grievances, illnesses, or community conflicts. [JAGARIYA] [DANGARIYA] [AUDIENCE / VILLAGE]



Key Ritual Roles

- **The Jagariya:** The master bard who sings long narrative legends while playing the *Hurka*, *Dhol*, or a brass plate (*Thali*). The rhythm gradually accelerates to invoke the spirit world.

- **The Dangariya:** The chosen human vessel or medium. As the musical tempo rises, the *Dangariya* enters a deep trance state (*Bhaan* or *Avatar*), physically embodying the invoked deity or spirit.
- **The Public / Petitioner:** Villagers present their grievances, questions, or requests to the possessed *Dangariya*, who delivers divine advice, prophecies, and remedies.

Cult of Golu Devta (God of Justice)

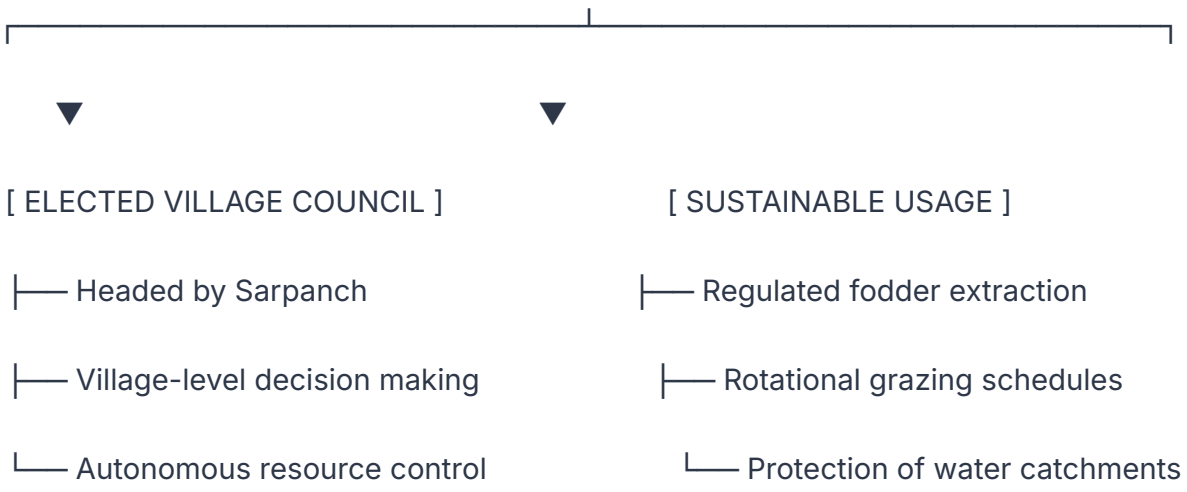
Golu Devta is worshipped across Kumaon as the supreme deity of justice.

- **Courts of Justice:** His primary shrines—notably at **Chitai** (Almora) and **Ghorakhal** (Nainital)—serve as legal altars where devotees submit written petitions (*Stamps/Stamp Papers*) detailing land disputes, family issues, or personal injustices.
- **Ritual Offerings:** When a petition is answered, devotees return to the temple to hang brass bells of various sizes. As a result, the courtyards of Chitai Golu Devta are lined with thousands of ringing bells.

Traditional Ecological Knowledge (TEK)

Van Panchayats (Forest Councils)

Established under the Kumaon Panchayat Forest Rules of **1931**, *Van Panchayats* represent one of the world's earliest legal models of community-managed forest governance.



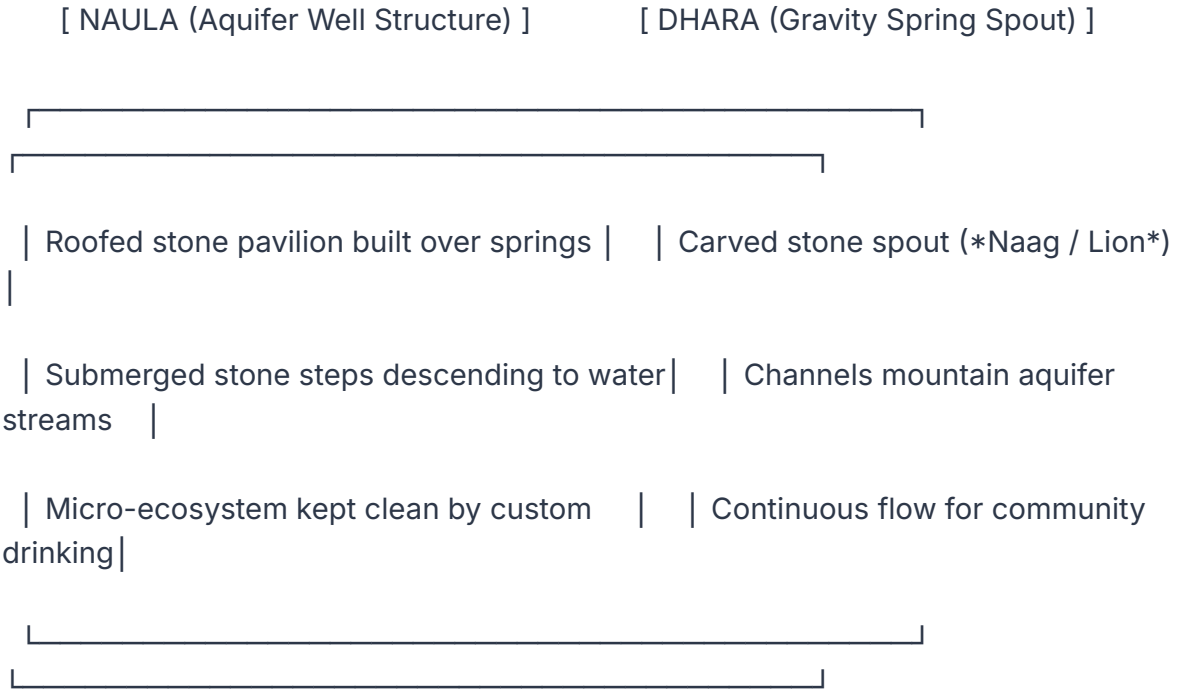
- **Structure:** Local villagers elect an autonomous executive body headed by a *Sarpanch* to manage local forest resources (*Civil/Soyam Forests*).
- **Function:** The council regulates rotational grazing, fodder collection, dry-firewood collection, and forest fire prevention, protecting local ecosystems through community oversight.

Ethnobotany & Alpine Herbs

Mountain communities have long drawn on traditional botanical knowledge to treat illness and sustain local livelihoods:

- **Yarsagumba / Keeda Jadi (*Ophiocordyceps sinensis*):** A rare fungus-caterpillar complex gathered in high alpine grasslands (above 3,500 m) during early summer; prized in traditional Asian medicine.
- **Kutki (*Picrorhiza kurroa*) & Atees (*Aconitum heterophyllum*):** High-altitude roots used in traditional remedies to treat fevers, digestive ailments, and liver disorders.
- **Brahma Kamal (*Saussurea obvallata*):** The state flower of Uttarakhand, growing in high-altitude scree slopes (3,700–4,600 m). Used both as a sacred offering at Kedarnath and Badrinath and as an ingredient in traditional bone and joint treatments.

Naulas and Dharas (Traditional Water Engineering)



- **Naula:** A covered, stone-lined step-well built over natural subterranean seepages and springs. Architecturally constructed like a small temple, a *Naula*

features a roofed pavilion and descending stone steps. Strict social norms prohibit footwear, washing, or pollution near the water, protecting the aquifer.

- **Dhara:** A gravity-fed water spout designed to channel mountain spring water for community use. The water outlets are frequently carved into the shapes of animal or mythical heads (*Naag*, *Simha*) made of cut stone.

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